
The Crosswalk Assessment

Three questions medical career quizzes don't ask, and what your honest answers actually mean.

From the Ward to the World

01 THE TRAP

Why this isn't another burnout quiz

Burnout inventories measure how tired you are. That's a real number, but it's not the number that decides anything. You can be well-rested and still stuck, or exhausted and still certain. What actually predicts whether someone stays, pivots, or spends five more years circling the question isn't their energy level, it's whether they can answer three specific questions honestly. Most people can't, because no one's ever asked them directly.

- ◆ Exhaustion tells you how you feel this week. These three questions tell you what's actually true underneath it.
- ◆ You can score low on burnout and still be trapped. You can score high on burnout and still be exactly where you want to be.

The first two questions

1. What am I afraid of losing?

Not the job, the specific thing under the job. The title on the intake form, the way a room goes quiet when you speak, the years already spent, the version of yourself that made the sacrifice worth it. Name the actual thing, not the category. "My career" is a category. "Never having to explain the gap on my resume" is the actual thing. If you can't get more specific than the category in under thirty seconds, that's data too.

2. How much of my identity is tied to my profession?

Ask it a sharper way: when you're introduced at a dinner party without your title attached, does the conversation still work? If the answer is an uneasy "I don't know," you've found the load-bearing wall. It's not wrong to have your identity connected to your work. It's only a problem when you've never checked how much weight that wall is actually carrying.

03 YOUR ASSETS

The third question, and what connects all three

3. Am I trapped, or do I feel trapped?

These have different fixes. Actually trapped means a real, external, nameable barrier: a licensing requirement, a visa condition, a contract. Feeling trapped means the barrier is real but has an edge you haven't found yet, or was real once and quietly expired. Most people never separate the two, so they treat a six-month process like a life sentence.

The pattern underneath all three

Each question is really asking the same thing from a different angle: how much of what you're carrying is the situation, and how much is the story you've told yourself about the situation. Proximity to something isn't the same as permission to do it. You can be standing right next to the work and still be nowhere close, and that gap has a specific shape once you look at it directly.

Why naming it changes anything

A vague sense of being stuck expands to fill however much attention you give it. A named barrier, this requirement, this timeline, this specific gap, shrinks to the size of an actual problem you can work on. The relief isn't in the answer. It's in the sentence becoming specific enough to attack.

Where your answers put you

Mostly clear, mostly named

You already know what you're afraid of losing, how tied your identity is, and whether the barrier is real or a habit of thinking. You're not stuck on information. You're stuck on the next concrete step, which is a much smaller problem than it feels like.

Clear on one, foggy on two

Common pattern: people usually have the identity question mapped and the trapped question foggy, or the reverse. Whichever one is foggy is the one worth an honest hour this week, not more research, an hour of plain-sentence writing about that one question alone.

Foggy on all three

That's not a character flaw, it's a sign no one has ever asked you these questions directly before today. Start with question one. The category answer ("my career") is fine as a first draft. Push it one layer specific and stop there for now.

Named the barrier and it's real

If question three lands on "actually trapped" with a specific, verifiable barrier, a licensing timeline, a contractual clause, that's not a dead end. That's a project plan with a start date, which is a very different thing to be standing in front of than a wall with no edges.

Your next honest step

1 1. Write all three answers as plain sentences

Not a paragraph, not a list of ten. One sentence per question. Say the specific version, not the category version. Read them back once.

2 2. Circle whichever sentence you flinched writing

That's the real one. The other two are usually easier to say out loud than they were to write down, which tells you something about which one's actually been running the show.

3 3. Test the "trapped" sentence against a calendar

If it names a real barrier, does that barrier have an actual date, requirement, or process attached to it? Write that down too. A dateless barrier is usually a feeling wearing a barrier's clothes.

4 4. Tell one specific person the flinch sentence

Not the polished version. The one you circled. Vague fears survive being kept private. Specific ones get smaller the moment someone else hears them and doesn't flinch back.

5 5. Pick the smallest next step on the real barrier, not the biggest

Not "resolve my entire career." Look up the actual requirement. Send the one email. Book the one call. The paralysis breaks on the small step every time.

6 6. Put a date on that one small step

Not "soon." A calendar date, this week. An assessment with no action attached to it is just a more articulate way of staying stuck. The point was never the three questions, it's the sentence you finally write down and act on.

You've seen the map. Now make the call.

The hard part isn't the plan — it's deciding, because deciding is exactly what sunk cost is built to stop. Take the Fear Audit to find which layer of the trap is holding you, then read The Courage to Choose for the full framework.

crosswalkwisdom.com